Oil Spill Reaches UAE Beaches and Moves Toward Turtle Islands

From: BBC News Mined: 2026-10-23 3 min read

Oil is spreading along the coast of the United Arab Emirates. At some beaches, the water has turned black.

The oil is leaking from a **tanker** called Gem No.2. The ship was damaged on October 9 near the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway many oil **tankers** pass through. A maritime company said the ship was hit by an unknown **projectile** and caught fire. The fire was put out, and all 22 crew members were rescued. A small leak was seen on October 19. Later, **satellite** pictures showed the oil spreading more than 35 kilometres (22 miles).

This week, oil reached beaches near the city of Umm Al Quwain, and some beaches were closed. The government said it began **containment** right away to limit the harm.

Oil can trap sea turtles, cover the feathers of seabirds, and hurt the **gills** of fish. The oil is drifting toward protected islands where green turtles live. Experts say it is too early to know how much harm it will cause.

Word Treasure

tanker -- A tanker is a huge ship that carries oil or other liquids across the sea.

projectile -- A projectile is an object that is thrown or fired through the air at something.

satellite -- A satellite is a machine in space that can take pictures of Earth from above.

containment -- Containment means stopping something harmful, like oil, from spreading further.

gills -- Gills are the body parts fish use to breathe underwater.

Background you need

Oil tankers are huge ships that carry oil across the sea, and many of them pass through narrow waterways like the Strait of Hormuz.

If a tanker is damaged, oil can leak into the water and slowly spread over the sea and onto beaches.

The sticky oil is dangerous for sea animals because it can trap turtles, cover the feathers of seabirds, and hurt the gills of fish.

Break it down

WHO: The tanker Gem No.2 and its crew, the government, and sea animals near the coast
WHAT: Oil leaking from the damaged tanker spread along the coast, reached beaches, and is drifting toward protected islands
WHERE: Along the coast of the United Arab Emirates, near the city of Umm Al Quwain
WHY: The tanker was damaged near the Strait of Hormuz and caught fire, so oil began leaking into the sea

Why it matters

Oil in the sea can close beaches where families swim and hurt the turtles, birds, and fish that live there.

Test what you remember

1. Where is the oil spreading?

- (A) In a river in the mountains
- (B) Across a desert
- (C) Along the coast of the United Arab Emirates
- (D) Inside a harbor warehouse

2. What is the name of the tanker the oil is leaking from?

- (A) Umm Al Quwain
- (B) Gem No.2
- (C) Strait of Hormuz
- (D) Green Turtle

3. What did a maritime company say happened to the ship?

- (A) It was emptied on purpose
- (B) It was hit by an unknown projectile and caught fire
- (C) It got stuck in sand
- (D) It ran out of fuel

4. What happened to all 22 crew members?

- (A) They stayed on the ship
- (B) They were hurt by oil
- (C) They swam to an island
- (D) They were rescued

5. Near which city did oil reach beaches this week?

- (A) Umm Al Quwain
- (B) The Strait of Hormuz
- (C) Chicago
- (D) New Haven

6. What can oil do to fish?

- (A) Feed them
- (B) Hurt their gills
- (C) Help them swim faster
- (D) Keep them warm

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. A maritime company: It said the ship was hit by an unknown projectile and caught fire.
2. The government: It said it began containment right away to limit the harm.
3. Experts: They say it is too early to know how much harm the oil will cause.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):